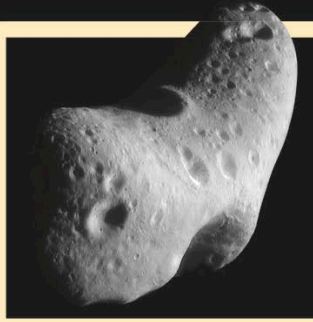


NEAR-Shoemaker

At the end of its mission, in February 2001, the team decided to try landing the probe on Eros to show that it could be done. As it neared the asteroid for landing it sent a series of 69 increasingly detailed shots of the surface.



February 2000
Eros picture made up from six images pieced together



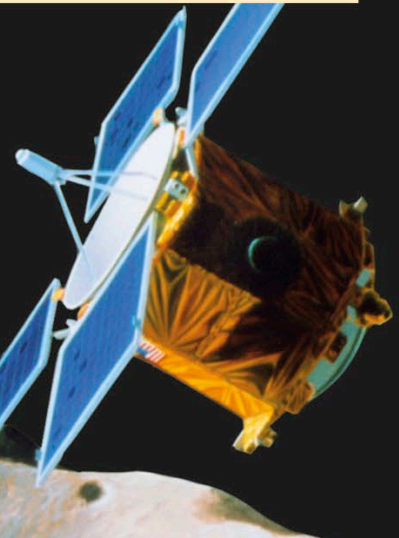
January 2001
Taken from 38 km (24 miles) above Eros, showing a crater



February 2001
Eros' surface taken from a distance of 700 m (2,300 ft)

What did the probe find?

Some asteroids are basically loose piles of rubble, moving together in space. Scientists discovered Eros to be solid. Like many other asteroids, it is perhaps as old as the Earth.



A close approach

NEAR-Shoemaker spent a year orbiting Eros, during which time it sent back lots of useful information to the Earth about the asteroid.

It takes Eros just over five hours to rotate on its axis.

Researchers have said that a person who could jump 1 m (3 ft) on the Earth, would be able to jump 1.6 km (1 mile) on Eros because of its weak gravity.